> Almost all the influential Chiefs for several miles round have come in to pay their respects . . . swearing faith to us & to tender aid in fighting men if required. Although we are still in the dark as to what our troops are doing or where they are we suppose they must be somewhere near Kabul & probably have had a fight with Akbar – in which case we shall not be surprised to see the latter with some 5 or 600 horsemen at any hour in our valley. We have turned our attention to the strengthening of our forts & clearing out the loop holes so as to give them a warm reception in the event of their interference with us.[70]

A week later, with Lady Sale at their head, the former hostages had even begun to tax passing caravans.

Early in the morning on 1 September, a solitary horseman rode up to a picket outside Pollock's camp at Jagdalak. When challenged by the sentry, the rider announced himself to be Shah Fatteh Jang.

It had been rumoured in the Bala Hisar towards the end of August that Akbar Khan had been making plans to kill the young successor to the Sadozai crown, after first having branded him with hot irons. As the rumour spread, the old retainers of the fort took action: they cut a hole in the mud roof of the prison where the Shah was being held and helped him out through a tunnel under the walls, then out to the Qizilbash quarter of Chindawal. There horses were waiting for him, ready saddled. Twenty-four hours later he was breakfasting with General Pollock.[71]

According to the traditions related by Fayz Mohammad, the young Shah then accused the British of failing his father Shuja and demanded that the British honour their commitment to the dynasty. 'The English campaign to seize Afghanistan had no other purpose aside from what the English thought might ultimately benefit themselves,' Fatteh Jang is supposed to have told Pollock.

> 'They never helped or even gave a thought to my murdered father . . . However I still consider myself bound to the [Tripartite] treaty which was concluded between the English government and my father and I have come to you so that if you still stand by your commitment, you will assist me and march on Kabul. Otherwise, there is no obligation on the part of the English government on my behalf, and your ambitions and your hostility will be revealed to all.' Shah Fatteh Jang's words were embarrassing to General Pollock and he prepared to aid the Shah out of a sense of decency, and so as to banish from people's lips the bad name ascribed to the English.[72]